



I BUILT ST. PETERSBURG AS A WINDOW TO LET IN THE LIGHT OF EUROPE

THE FOUNDING OF ST. PETERSBURG (1703)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

The rise of Russia

BEFORE

1584 The emperor Ivan the Terrible dies. The following succession of rulers bring greater unity to Russia.

1696 Peter the Great assumes sole rule of Russia.

AFTER

1709 Russia wins a decisive victory over Sweden at the Battle of Poltava.

1718 Peter's son Alexis, opposed to his father's reforms, dies under torture.

1721 Russia and Sweden sign the Treaty of Nystad, pledging mutual defense.

1725 Peter the Great dies, ushering in an era of less competent emperors.

1762 Catherine the Great becomes empress and continues Peter's work of reform and expansion.



St. Petersburg offered a new vision for the country. Its strategic location facilitated trade, its ethos encouraged education, and its architecture provided a showcase for Russian achievement.

An admirer of Western palaces, Peter employed European architects to design the government buildings, palaces, university, and houses in the fashionable baroque style. He also pressed 30,000 peasants each year into construction gangs, along with Russian convict laborers and Swedish prisoners of war. The regimen was strict, and living conditions stark: more than 100,000 workers died, but those who survived could earn their freedom.

The lavish design and vast scale of Peter's architecture showed not only his appreciation of European culture, but also his determination to be an exalted, absolute ruler in the manner of Western despots such as Louis XIV. Peter used his power to make significant changes in Russia. He founded the Russian navy and reformed the army, which until then had relied on bands of men led by untrained village elders. He reorganized the army along European lines and developed new

Russian ruler Peter the Great founded St. Petersburg, on the estuary of the Neva River, on May 27, 1703. This new city, fortress, and port by the Baltic gave Russia direct sea access to Europe, opening new opportunities for both trade and military conquest. In 1712, Peter made his new city Russia's capital, stripping the title from the ancient seat of Moscow.